AyurvedAI

AI-powered Ayurvedic knowledge and healthcare information system

Ayurvedic Knowledge Sheet

15 herbs and formulations in detail: names, botanical identity, Ayurvedic properties (rasa, guna, virya, vipaka), traditional uses, constituents, modern evidence, safety, interactions and recent regulatory news (2013 to 2026).

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Important: This document is for education and information only. It does not diagnose, treat or prescribe. Classical doses are shown as reference ranges from the cited sources and are not recommendations. Always consult a qualified Ayurvedic doctor (BAMS) or physician before using any herb, especially in pregnancy, with prescription medicines, or with liver, kidney, heart or autoimmune disease. Content is awaiting expert Ayurvedic review.

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How to read this sheet

Each entry follows the same order: names, botanical identity, parts used, Ayurvedic properties, traditional uses, constituents, modern evidence, safety and regulation. Every paragraph starts with the herb name so it can be understood on its own.

Source quality. Facts on botany, constituents, evidence, safety and regulation come from the web sources listed at the end (Wikipedia, PubMed Central, NutraIngredients, Ayurvedic college and journal pages). Where a heading says *commonly cited classical summary*, the rasa, guna, virya and vipaka values are the standard textbook summary and were not individually confirmed online for this sheet; classical texts often disagree with one another, as the Ashwagandha entry shows.

Safety, regulatory and conservation updates (2013 to 2026)

The items below are recent or specialised facts that general AI models often do not know or may get wrong. They are repeated in the herb entries.

Liver safety overview (2024 review of Ayush herbs): A 2024 review of hepatotoxicity of herbs used in the Indian Ayush systems reports herb-induced liver injury for three popular herbs. Giloy (Guduchi) is described as the highest reported cause of herb-induced liver injury in India; the LIVERECI nationwide study included 43 giloy patients. Ashwagandha reports are rising: LIVERECI recorded 23 patients, with 3 deaths from acute-on-chronic liver failure. Turmeric injury is mostly hepatocellular and linked to highly bioavailable concentrated formulations. The review did not cover neem, guggul, Brahmi, arjuna, Haritaki, amla, Shatavari, licorice, tulsi, ginger or long pepper.

Ashwagandha - 2026 India leaf advisory: On 16 April 2026 the Ministry of Ayush issued an advisory restricting ashwagandha leaves in any form, allowing only root, because of possible safety concerns about reactive withanolides such as withaferin A. The Karnataka High Court granted an interim stay in mid-May 2026, and the Kerala High Court granted two further stays; 16 companies had petitioned. The leaf restriction was therefore not being enforced when last reported (NutraIngredients, 6 July 2026).

Ashwagandha - Europe: Denmark banned ashwagandha in food supplements in 2023. The Netherlands advised against use in spring 2024. France issued precautionary advice in 2024. The UK Food Standards Agency started a call for evidence in 2024. The EU is considering an Article 8 review, and the EU Heads of Food Safety Agencies proposed restricting 12 critical botanicals in 2024, although it was not confirmed that ashwagandha is on that list.

Turmeric - adulteration alert: The US FDA issued import alerts from 2013 to 2019 on turmeric from India and Bangladesh because of lead chromate adulteration (up to 500 times the Bangladesh limit).

Neem - toxicity and legal status: Neem oil can be fatal to small children. Neem is a declared weed in the Northern Territory of Australia since April 2015. A 1995 European patent on a neem antifungal was revoked in 2005 after an Indian challenge.

Guggul - conservation: Commiphora wightii (Guggul) is Critically Endangered on the IUCN Red List, with wild populations in Gujarat and Rajasthan under pressure from overharvesting.

Bacopa - FDA warnings: In 2019 the US FDA sent warning letters to makers of Bacopa monnieri supplements for illegal disease claims, and said no Bacopa product is approved for medical purposes.

Licorice - daily limit: Some jurisdictions suggest no more than 100-200 mg of glycyrrhizin per day, and side effects can appear above about 0.2 mg per kg of body weight per day.

Shatavari - 2026 trial: A 2026 randomised, double-blind, placebo-controlled trial in women with polycystic ovarian syndrome reported decreased follicular count and increased endometrial thickness with Shatavari.

Ashwagandha

Withania somnifera

AYU-001
Herb (root)

Ashwagandha - Names: Ashwagandha, also called Indian ginseng and winter cherry. The Sanskrit name comes from ashva (horse) plus gandha (smell), because the fresh root smells like a horse. Classical synonyms in the Dhanvantari Nighantu include Vajigandha, Kanchuka, Ashwarohaka, Varahakarni, Turagi, Balya and Vajikari.

Ashwagandha - Botanical identity: *Withania somnifera* (L.) Dunal, family Solanaceae (the nightshade family). IUCN conservation status: Least Concern.

Ashwagandha - Parts used: The root is the traditional part, usually as root powder (churna). Leaf powder and root or leaf extracts are common in modern products.

Ashwagandha - Ayurvedic properties (per classical Nighantus; the texts differ): Dhanvantari Nighantu: rasa Kasaya and Katu, virya Ushna, Vata-Kapha shamaka. Madanapala Nighantu: Tikta and Kasaya, Ushna, Kapha-Vata shamaka. Bhavaprakasha Nighantu: Kasaya and Tikta, Ushna; its table says Vata-Pitta shamaka while its text says Vata-Kapha shamaka. Raja Nighantu: Katu, Ushna, Vata shamaka. A Kerala Ayurveda source lists Tikta rasa and Madhura vipaka and calls it useful in Vata disorders. The virya (potency) is Ushna (hot) in every text that states it.

Ashwagandha - Traditional uses: Rasayana (rejuvenative), balya (strength-giving), brimhaniya (nourishing) and vrishya or vajikarana (vitality). Bhavaprakasha describes it as balakaraka, sukravardhaka and rasayana, relieving swelling (sotha). Kaiyadeva adds wounds, itching, worms, breathlessness (swasa) and cough (kasa). The Charaka Samhita lists it among the Brimhaniya and Balya Mahakashayas and in Vajikarana ghrita.

Ashwagandha - Key constituents: Withanolides (triterpene lactones including withaferin A, structurally similar to ginsenosides, which is why it is called Indian ginseng), alkaloids (tropine, cuscohygrine) and sitoindosides. About 40 withanolides and 12 alkaloids have been isolated from the species.

Ashwagandha - Modern evidence: Root extract at 300-600 mg per day for three months may help generalised anxiety disorder, but the evidence is tentative. A 2021 review (Cheah et al.) found modest improvement in sleep quality, more noticeable in people with insomnia at higher doses and longer durations. Overall, current clinical evidence is not enough to confirm safety or efficacy.

Ashwagandha - Safety and liver injury: Generally well tolerated for up to about three months; common effects are diarrhoea, headache, sedation and nausea. Herb-induced liver injury is rare but documented. A 2024 review of Ayush herbs describes prolonged cholestatic hepatitis, with a higher risk of death in people with cirrhosis. Reported numbers: first report from Japan in 2017 (a 20-year-old man); Iceland and US DILIN series in 2020 with 5 patients; LIVERECI series from India with 23 patients, of whom 8 were attributed to a single-component formulation and 3 died of acute-on-chronic liver failure; Netherlands Lareb 4 cases; WHO VigiBase 15 cases.

Ashwagandha - Interactions, pregnancy and who should avoid it: It may raise testosterone, which could interact with cancer medicines, and it is not recommended for hormone-sensitive conditions such as hormone-sensitive prostate cancer. It should be avoided during pregnancy.

Ashwagandha - Regulatory timeline 2020-2026 (as reported): Denmark banned ashwagandha in food supplements in 2023, after a 2020 DTU risk assessment on reproductive, thyroid, immune and nervous-system concerns, and alerted other EU states through RASFF. Sweden, Finland and France opened investigations in 2023. The Netherlands (RIVM, spring 2024) advised against use, citing liver toxicity and hormone interactions. France (ANSES, 2024) issued precautionary advice to avoid it in pregnancy, breastfeeding, minors and people with thyroid, liver or heart conditions (advice, not a ban). The UK Food Standards Agency opened a call for evidence in 2024 with no decision reported. India: a Ministry of Ayush advisory dated 16 April 2026 restricted ashwagandha leaves (root only) because of reactive withanolides such as withaferin A; the Karnataka High Court granted an interim stay in mid-May 2026 and the Kerala High Court granted further stays. The EU is considering an Article 8 review. Status as reported by NutraIngredients on 6 July 2026; check for newer news.

Neem

Azadirachta indica

AYU-002
Herb (leaf, bark, seed oil)

Neem - Names: Neem is called Nimba in Sanskrit (the source of the Hindustani word nim), and also margosa or Indian lilac. Classical synonyms include Pichumarda, Arishta and Hingu-niryasa.

Neem - Botanical identity: *Azadirachta indica* A.Juss., family Meliaceae (the mahogany family), native to the Indian subcontinent. IUCN status: Least Concern.

Neem - Parts used: Leaf, bark, flowers, fruit and seed (seed oil, taila), twigs (traditional tooth-cleaning sticks) and gum.

Neem - Ayurvedic properties: Rasa Tikta (bitter) and Kashaya (astringent); guna Laghu (light); virya Sheeta (cooling); vipaka Katu (pungent). It alleviates Pitta and Kapha. (Himalayan Voices monograph; a Kerala source also lists Tikta rasa, Seetha virya and Laghu guna.)

Neem - Traditional uses: Charaka Samhita: kandughna (relieves itching). A Kerala source lists skin disorders, mouth ulcers, diabetes (prameha), swelling and worms, and calls neem a purifying medicine. Leaves and flowers are eaten at festivals such as Ugadi, and dried leaves are kept in grain stores and cupboards to deter insects.

Neem - Classical dose forms (reference only, not a recommendation): A monograph lists churna (powder) 2-4 g, swarasa (fresh juice) 10-20 ml and taila (oil) 5-10 drops. Any actual use should be decided by a qualified practitioner.

Neem - Key constituents: Azadirachtin (a limonoid, about 2 percent of the oil), nimbolide and related limonoids, glycerides, polyphenols and beta-sitosterol. Leaves contain quercetin, catechins, carotenes and vitamin C.

Neem - Modern evidence: There is insufficient clinical evidence for medicinal benefits. Azadirachtin is well established as an insecticide, antifeedant and insect growth disruptor, and neem extract is added to urea fertilizer as a nitrification inhibitor.

Neem - Safety and who should avoid it: Neem oil is toxic to small children and can be fatal. Neem may cause miscarriage, infertility and low blood sugar, so it should be avoided in pregnancy and when trying to conceive.

Neem - Regulation and history: The Northern Territory of Australia declared neem a class B and C weed in April 2015, making it illegal to buy, sell or transport plants or seeds there. The European Patent Office granted a 1995 patent on a neem antifungal product, which was revoked in 2005 after India challenged it.

Turmeric

Curcuma longa

AYU-003
Herb (rhizome)

Turmeric - Names: Turmeric is Haridra in Sanskrit and haldi in Hindi. Botanical synonym: *Curcuma domestica* Valeton. Turmeric milk is called haldi doodh, and the haldi ceremony is part of Indian weddings.

Turmeric - Botanical identity: *Curcuma longa* L., family Zingiberaceae (the ginger family). A perennial rhizomatous herb up to about 1 m tall, native to the Indian subcontinent and Southeast Asia.

Turmeric - Parts used: The dried, cured rhizome. Leaves are used in some Indian sweets and as a dye source in some places.

Turmeric - Ayurvedic properties (Ayurvedic Pharmacopoeia of India, as cited): Rasa Katu (pungent) and Tikta (bitter); guna Ruksha (dry); virya Ushna (hot); vipaka Katu. Classical actions: krimighna (anti-worm), kushtaghna (skin diseases), varnya (improves complexion), vishaghna (anti-toxic) and pramehanashaka (diabetes and urinary disorders). A Kerala source warns that it can cause dryness if overused.

Turmeric - Traditional uses: A study of Haridra lists use in diabetes, skin diseases, jaundice, menstrual disorders, haematuria, haemorrhage and colic pain. It is the main ingredient of Haridra Khanda, indicated in Sheetapitta (urticaria), and is applied as a skin paste and for non-healing ulcers.

Turmeric - Curcumin content: Curcuminoids make up about 1-6 percent of turmeric powder (a range flagged as unverified on Wikipedia). One assay found an average of 3.14 percent curcumin by weight in commercial turmeric powder, and only 0.29 percent in curry powder.

Turmeric - Modern evidence: There is no high-quality clinical evidence that turmeric or curcumin treats any disease. Weak evidence suggests it may ease knee osteoarthritis symptoms and exercise-related muscle pain. The EMA (2019) found insufficient evidence of efficacy but accepted traditional use of oral turmeric for mild digestive complaints such as fullness and flatulence.

Turmeric - Safety and liver injury: Turmeric as a food spice is generally considered safe. Rare, potentially serious immune-mediated liver injury has been linked mainly to high-bioavailability supplements and to genetically susceptible people. A 2024 review reports 7 cases from Tuscany (Italian Phytovigilance), 23 cases in a systematic review, and a US DILIN series of 10 cases (mostly women, median age 56) with one death from acute liver failure; 7 patients carried the gene variant HLA-B*35:01. Australia's TGA issued a warning. It usually resolves after stopping, but it can be severe if use continues.

Turmeric - Adulteration and regulation: The US FDA issued import alerts from 2013 to 2019 on turmeric from India and Bangladesh because of lead chromate adulteration, which reached up to 500 times the national limit in Bangladesh. Metanil yellow is an illegal food dye in the UK. Turmeric is approved as a food additive by WHO, the EU (E100) and the US FDA.

Tulsi

Ocimum tenuiflorum

AYU-004
Herb (leaf)

Tulsi - Names: Tulsi is Tulasi in Sanskrit and is known in English as holy basil. Botanical synonym: *Ocimum sanctum* L.

Tulsi - Botanical identity: *Ocimum tenuiflorum* L., family Lamiaceae. An aromatic, erect, many-branched perennial subshrub 30-60 cm tall with hairy stems, strongly scented ovate leaves up to 5 cm and purplish flowers in whorls.

Tulsi - Varieties: Rama tulsi has broad bright-green leaves and is the most common type. Krishna or Shyama tulsi has purplish-green leaves and is less common. Vana tulsi is a wild type (one example given is *Ocimum gratissimum*).

Tulsi - Parts used: Leaves, essential oil and wood (used for prayer beads). Dried leaves are also mixed with stored grain to repel insects.

Tulsi - Ayurvedic properties (Kerala Ayurveda source; texts differ): Rasa Kashaya and Tikta; virya Ushna; vipaka Katu; guna Teekshna. It reduces Kapha and Vata. Listed uses are respiratory illness, with the leaf juice used for cough. Tulsi tea is a common Ayurvedic preparation.

Tulsi - Key constituents: Tannins, flavonoids, eugenol, caryophyllenes, carvacrol, linalool, camphor and cinnamyl acetate. Ten neolignans called tulsinol A to J were reported in one study. The essential oil varies by genotype; one study found mostly eugenol (about 70 percent).

Tulsi - Modern evidence: There is little clinical evidence. The only specific activity described in the Wikipedia source is that the essential oil may have nematicidal properties against several plant-parasitic nematodes. Medicinal claims are mostly traditional.

Tulsi - Cultural and religious importance: Tulsi is central to the Vaishnava tradition of Hinduism, and Vaishnavites are sometimes called those who bear the tulsi around the neck. It is planted in the courtyards of Hindu houses and in temples to Hanuman, worshipped in evening lamp rituals in Kartik, and honoured at the Tulasi Vivaha festival held between Prabodhini Ekadashi and Kartik Purnima. In Assam, Kati Bihu includes lighting lamps at the base of household tulsi plants.

Tulsi - Culinary use and safety note: Related basil types are used in Thai phat kaphrao and Minangkabau gulai dishes. The sources used for this sheet do not cover tulsi safety data, so people who are pregnant, on blood-thinning or blood-sugar medicines, or with chronic illness should ask a qualified practitioner before taking it medicinally.

Amla

Phyllanthus emblica

AYU-005
Herb (fruit)

Amla - Names: Amla is Amalaki or Amalaka in Sanskrit, and is called Indian gooseberry, emblic or emblic myrobalan in English. Other forms: amloki.

Amla - Botanical identity: *Phyllanthus emblica* L. (synonym *Emblica officinalis*), family Phyllanthaceae. IUCN status: Least Concern.

Amla - Parts used: The fruit, fresh or dried, is the part used in Ayurvedic preparations. The inner bark is used as a flavouring in a Batak fish soup in Sumatra, which is a culinary rather than medicinal use.

Amla - Ayurvedic properties (commonly cited classical summary; sources vary): Amla is classically said to contain all tastes except salty (lavana), with sour (amla) predominant; guna Laghu and Ruksha; virya Sheeta (cooling); vipaka Madhura; and it is considered balancing for all three doshas, especially Pitta.

Amla - Key constituents: The fruit is very high in ascorbic acid (vitamin C). Its bitterness is attributed to ellagitannins: emblicanin A (37 percent), emblicanin B (33 percent), punigluconin (12 percent) and pedunculagin (14 percent). Other polyphenols include punicafolin, phyllanemblinin A, kaempferol, ellagic acid and gallic acid.

Amla - Role in formulations: Dried and fresh amla fruit is a common constituent of Ayurvedic preparations. It is one of the three fruits of Triphala together with Haritaki and Vibhitaki.

Amla - Modern evidence: The Wikipedia source lists studies on antioxidant activity but gives no clinical findings. Clinical evidence for specific health claims is limited.

Amla - Safety: The sources used for this sheet do not describe amla safety or interactions. As with any herb, people who are pregnant, on regular medicines or with chronic illness should consult a qualified practitioner.

Brahmi

Bacopa monnieri

AYU-006
Herb (whole plant)

Brahmi - Names: Brahmi, water hyssop, herb of grace, Indian pennywort and thyme-leafed gratiola. Note: in some regions the name Brahmi is also used for another plant, *Centella asiatica* (Mandukaparni), so labels should always be checked for the botanical name.

Brahmi - Botanical identity: *Bacopa monnieri* (L.) Pennell, family Plantaginaceae. IUCN status: Least Concern.

Brahmi - Ayurvedic properties (commonly cited classical summary; sources vary): Rasa Tikta and Kashaya, with sweetness mentioned in some texts; virya Sheeta (cooling); vipaka Madhura. Traditionally regarded as a medhya (mind-supporting) herb.

Brahmi - Traditional uses: Used in Ayurveda in the belief that it may improve memory and treat various ailments, and widely taken in stress and cognitive-support formulations.

Brahmi - Key constituents: Bacosides, which are dammarane-type triterpenoid saponins with jujubogenin or pseudojujubogenin aglycones (12 known bacoside analogues), bacopasides I to XII, alkaloids (brahmine, nicotine, herpestine), D-mannitol, apigenin and cucurbitacin.

Brahmi - Modern evidence: Evidence is inconclusive. There is no good evidence that Bacopa improves cognitive performance or memory.

Brahmi - Safety: Safety and effectiveness remain uncertain. The most commonly reported adverse effects in people are nausea, increased intestinal motility and gastrointestinal upset.

Brahmi - Regulation: In 2019 the US FDA sent warning letters to supplement makers for unproven and illegal health claims, including claims about Alzheimer's disease, anxiety and blood pressure. The FDA stated that no *B. monnieri* products have been approved for medical purposes.

Guduchi

Tinospora cordifolia

AYU-007
Herb (stem)

Guduchi - Names: Guduchi, also Amrita (nectar), Guruchi and, in Hindi, Giloy. English: heart-leaved moonseed.

Guduchi - Botanical identity: *Tinospora cordifolia* (Thunb.) Miers, family Menispermaceae. A large deciduous climbing vine native to South and Southeast Asia.

Guduchi - Parts used: All parts are used traditionally, with the stem considered the best (Kerala Ayurveda source).

Guduchi - Ayurvedic properties (Kerala Ayurveda source): Rasa Tikta; virya Ushna; vipaka Madhura. It reduces Kapha, increases agni (digestive fire) and digests ama (toxic residue).

Guduchi - Traditional uses: A rasayana (rejuvenative). Listed uses include jwara (fever), kamala (jaundice), prameha (urinary and diabetic disorders) and skin diseases.

Guduchi - Key constituents: Alkaloids, phytosterols, glycosides and tinosporide (a diterpenoid furanolactone). Furano-diterpenoids are named as likely contributors to liver toxicity.

Guduchi - Modern evidence: Reviews of clinical research found no evidence of any effect, and there is no good evidence that Guduchi benefits health as a medicine.

Guduchi - Safety and liver injury: Guduchi can cause potentially fatal herb-induced liver injury and is the most frequently reported supplement cause of herb-induced liver injury in India. During the 2020-22 COVID-19 outbreak the Ministry of AYUSH recommended giloy as a home remedy for immune support; Jaslok Hospital in Mumbai then reported hepatitis in six people who used boiled or capsule preparations. A 2021 case series (Nagral et al.) and a 2022 multicentre nationwide study (Kulkarni et al., 43 patients, more than half female) followed. The typical pattern is autoimmune-like hepatitis or unmasking of a silent autoimmune liver disease. The 2024 Ayush review calls giloy the highest reported cause of herb-induced liver injury in India; death is rare, but fatal worsening of cirrhosis and transplant-requiring acute liver failure have occurred. Investigators attributed the toxicity to compounds in the plant itself, not to adulteration. People with liver disease or autoimmune disease should avoid it unless a doctor advises otherwise.

Shatavari

Asparagus racemosus

AYU-008
Herb (tuberous root)

Shatavari - Names: Shatavari, meaning roughly one who has a hundred roots or husbands. Synonyms in the Bhavaprakasha Nighantu: Shatmuuli, Atirasa, Bahusuta, Shatpadi, Shatviryaa, Bhiru and Indivari. English: asparagus fern.

Shatavari - Botanical identity: *Asparagus racemosus* Willd., family Asparagaceae. Native range from Africa through southern Asia to northern Australia. Aboriginal people of the Northern Territory used the boiled roots externally.

Shatavari - Parts used: Tuberous roots.

Shatavari - Ayurvedic properties (Shri Dhanwantry Ayurvedic College): Rasa Madhura (sweet) and Tikta (bitter); guna Guru (heavy) and Snigdha (unctuous); virya Sita (cooling); vipaka Madhura.

Shatavari - Karma (actions) and indications: Rasayana, vrishya, stanyajanana (promotes breast milk), hridya and balya; also diuretic, constipating, carminative, nervine and uterine tonic. Indications include stanya kshaya (low milk), artava kshaya (scanty menses), rakta pitta, arshas (piles), atisara, grahani, kshaya and gulma. Modern listings add gout, puerperal diseases, haematuria, bleeding disorders, leucorrhoea and epilepsy.

Shatavari - Classical dose forms (reference only, not a recommendation): Fresh juice 10-20 ml, decoction 50-100 ml, powder 3-5 g, as listed by an Ayurvedic college. Actual use should be decided by a qualified practitioner.

Shatavari - Key constituents: Steroidal saponins (shatavarins and shatavarosides), mucilage, the alkaloid asparagamine A (a polycyclic alkaloid) and an isoflavone.

Shatavari - Modern evidence: A 2026 randomised, double-blind, placebo-controlled trial in women with polycystic ovarian syndrome reported decreased follicular count and increased endometrial thickness. Overall, clinical evidence is limited in quality, and lactation studies showed no significant effects.

Shatavari - Safety, pregnancy and lactation: Safety is not well studied. Two small trials found no adverse effects in mothers or babies. It is used traditionally in pregnancy, but no pregnancy safety data are given in the sources, so a qualified practitioner or doctor should be consulted.

Triphala

Haritaki + Vibhitaki + Amalaki

AYU-009
Classical formulation (churna)

Triphala - Names and composition: Triphala (Sanskrit: three fruits) is a polyherbal Ayurvedic formula of three myrobalans: Haritaki (*Terminalia chebula*, chebulic myrobalan), Vibhitaki (*Terminalia bellirica*, beleric myrobalan) and Amalaki (*Phyllanthus emblica*, emblic myrobalan or amla).

Triphala - Ratio and preparation: The dried fruit powders are usually mixed 1:1:1 or 1:2:3. Dosage forms are churna (powder), kwatha (decoction) and infusion.

Triphala - Reported bioactive compounds: Gallic acid, chebulagic acid, ellagic acid, flavonoids and tannins; it also contains vitamin C.

Triphala - Traditional uses: Used traditionally for metabolic and gastrointestinal conditions. It is described as a rasayana (rejuvenative) formula that balances all three doshas. The Charaka Samhita records a Triphala Rasayana taken with honey and ghee, said to promote longevity; this is a traditional claim, not an established finding.

Triphala - Modern evidence: Preclinical studies have looked at glucose metabolism, lipid profiles and oxidative stress, and at antioxidant, antimicrobial and anti-inflammatory properties. Large-scale clinical trials are still needed to confirm efficacy, so clinical evidence is limited. Current research focuses on standardising formulations, bioavailability, optimal dosing and nanoparticle delivery.

Triphala - Safety: The sources used for this sheet do not describe Triphala side effects, pregnancy safety or contamination such as heavy metals; toxicology studies on safety and herb-drug interactions are ongoing. Use products from reliable manufacturers and ask a qualified practitioner, especially in pregnancy or when taking regular medicines.

Ginger

Zingiber officinale

AYU-010
Herb (rhizome)

Ginger - Names: Ginger is Ardraka when fresh and Shunthi when dried in Ayurveda. The English word comes from the Sanskrit shringavera.

Ginger - Botanical identity: *Zingiber officinale* Roscoe, family Zingiberaceae. Relatives include turmeric, cardamom and galangal.

Ginger - Parts used: The rhizome. In some Vietnamese dishes fresh leaves are used as a garnish.

Ginger - Ayurvedic properties (commonly cited classical summary; sources vary): Rasa Katu (pungent); virya Ushna (hot); vipaka Madhura. Dried ginger (Shunthi) is described as Laghu and Snigdha and fresh ginger (Ardraka) as Guru and Teekshna. It is considered to pacify Vata and Kapha.

Ginger - Key constituents: Volatile oils make up 1-3 percent of fresh ginger weight, mainly sesquiterpenes such as beta-bisabolene and zingiberene. Pungent compounds are gingerols (6-gingerol is the main one), shogaols and zingerone. Zingerone forms from gingerols during drying, and shogaols form from gingerols with heat, storage or acid and are more pungent. About 400 compounds are present in raw ginger, including zingibain, a protease with rennet-like properties.

Ginger - Modern evidence: For pregnancy nausea ginger may help more than placebo, but the evidence is low quality. There is no good evidence of benefit for chemotherapy nausea, and it was not effective for dysmenorrhoea. There is some anti-inflammatory evidence for osteoarthritis but not enough to show pain relief. A 2018 review found reduced body weight in obese people and increased HDL cholesterol. Overall it remains uncertain whether ginger effectively treats any disease.

Ginger - Safety and interactions: Ginger is generally recognised as safe by the US FDA. Large amounts may cause stomach discomfort, and heartburn can occur, especially with powdered forms. It may affect people with gallstones. It interacts with anticoagulants (warfarin and aspirin), the heart medicine nifedipine and other prescription drugs. There is no clear evidence that using ginger for pregnancy nausea is safe.

Haritaki

Terminalia chebula

AYU-011
Herb (fruit)

Haritaki - Names: Haritaki, with Sanskrit synonyms Pathya, Abhaya and Mata; Hindi: Harad; English: chebulic or black myrobalan.

Haritaki - Botanical identity: *Terminalia chebula* Retz., family Combretaceae, native to South Asia and parts of Southeast and East Asia.

Haritaki - Parts used: The dried immature and mature fruit, mostly the outer skin.

Haritaki - Ayurvedic properties (Himalayan Voices monograph): Rasa: Madhura (sweet), Amla (sour), Katu (pungent), Tikta (bitter) and Kashaya (astringent), that is five tastes with salty (lavana) absent; guna Laghu (light) and Ruksha (dry); virya Ushna (hot); vipaka Madhura. Prabhava: tridoshahara, alleviating Vata, Pitta and Kapha but especially effective for Vata diseases.

Haritaki - Traditional uses (Charaka Samhita): Listed as prajasthapana (fertility promoter), jwaraghna (anti-fever), kushthaghna (for stubborn skin disease), kasaghna (anti-cough) and arshoghna (for piles).

Haritaki - Classical dose form (reference only, not a recommendation): Churna 3-6 g as listed in a monograph. Actual use should be decided by a qualified practitioner.

Haritaki - Key constituents: Triterpenes (arjunglucoside I, arjungenin, chebulosides I and II), chebulin (a coumarin-gallic acid conjugate), and phenolics and tannins including ellagic acid, chebulinic acid, gallic acid, ethyl gallate, punicalagin, tannic acid, terflavin A and B, terchebin and chebulic acid, plus the flavonoid luteolin.

Haritaki - Other uses and history: The fruit is picked green and pickled, boiled in syrup or made into preserves, and is used for leather tanning and cloth dyeing. A Kakatiya-era foundation technique reportedly mixed the black myrobalan fruit (karakkaya) with sand, lime and jaggery. Haritaki is a main ingredient of Triphala.

Haritaki - Modern evidence and safety: Fruit extracts have shown antibacterial activity in laboratory studies, and other studies in cells and animals looked at antioxidant and anticancer effects. Clinical effectiveness has not been established, and the sources used do not cover safety, interactions or pregnancy.

Arjuna

Terminalia arjuna

AYU-012
Herb (bark)

Arjuna - Names: Arjuna (Sanskrit), also called the arjun tree.

Arjuna - Botanical identity: *Terminalia arjuna* (Roxb.) Wight and Arn., family Combretaceae, in the same genus as Haritaki and Vibhitaki.

Arjuna - Parts used: The bark is the part traditionally used in Ayurveda (commonly cited; not detailed in the web sources used for this sheet).

Arjuna - Ayurvedic properties (commonly cited classical summary; sources vary): Rasa Kashaya (astringent); guna Laghu and Ruksha; virya Sheeta (cooling); vipaka Katu. It is considered to pacify Kapha and Pitta.

Arjuna - Traditional uses: Arjuna bark is traditionally regarded as hridya, a heart-supporting herb, and is used in classical cardiac tonics. Wikipedia describes the tree simply as a traditional medicinal plant; a published study examined analgesic and anti-inflammatory activity of the leaf.

Arjuna - Key constituents (commonly reported): Tannins and triterpenoids such as arjunolic acid. These constituents were not detailed in the web sources used for this sheet.

Arjuna - Safety: The sources used for this sheet do not give arjuna safety, interaction or pregnancy data. Because it is traditionally used for heart health, people with heart disease or on heart medicines should only use it under a doctor's supervision.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu)

Glycyrrhiza glabra

AYU-013
Herb (root)

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Names: Yashtimadhu in Sanskrit, and mulethi or muleti in Hindi. English: licorice (US) or liquorice (UK). The name derives from Greek glykyrrhiza, meaning sweet root.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Botanical identity: *Glycyrrhiza glabra* L., family Fabaceae (the bean family), a herbaceous perennial legume native to West Asia, tropical Asia, North Africa and Southern Europe. A related species, *G. uralensis*, is used in traditional Chinese medicine.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Parts used: The root, from which a sweet aromatic flavouring is extracted.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Ayurvedic properties (Kerala Ayurveda source): Rasa Madhura (sweet); guna Guru (heavy); virya Seetha (cooling). The source says it nourishes all three doshas.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Traditional uses: Listed uses include throat and respiratory infections, ulcers, mucositis, hair fall, blood sugar, immunity and weight reduction.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Key constituent: Glycyrrhizin, a glycoside making up about 7-10 percent of the root depending on cultivation. It is roughly 30-50 times sweeter than sugar.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Modern evidence: Glycyrrhizin is under preliminary research for hepatitis C and for topical treatment of psoriasis, but as of 2017 the studies were of low quality, so no conclusions can be drawn.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Safety (important): Too much licorice can cause high blood pressure, low blood potassium (hypokalaemia), muscle weakness, oedema and weight changes through apparent mineralocorticoid excess, in which the body retains sodium and loses potassium. People with hypertension, heart disease or kidney disease are especially at risk. Side effects can occur above about 0.2 mg of glycyrrhizin per kg of body weight per day.

Licorice (Yashtimadhu) - Pregnancy and regulatory limits: Licorice root extract should be avoided in pregnancy; large intakes have been linked to premature birth and child health problems. The US FDA considers licorice and its derivatives generally recognised as safe as a food ingredient if not consumed excessively, and some jurisdictions suggest no more than 100-200 mg of glycyrrhizin per day.

Guggul

Commiphora wightii

AYU-014
Herb (gum resin)

Guggul - Names: Guggulu or Guggul; also gugal, gugul, guggal, Indian bdellium-tree and mukul myrrh tree. Botanical synonyms: *Commiphora mukul* and *Commiphora roxburghii*. The extract is called gugulipid or guggulipid.

Guggul - Botanical identity: *Commiphora wightii* (Arn.) Bhandari, family Burseraceae (order Sapindales).

Guggul - Parts used: The gummy resin (gum guggulu), harvested by tapping the bark.

Guggul - Ayurvedic properties (commonly cited classical summary; sources vary): Rasa Tikta, Katu and Kashaya; virya Ushna (hot); vipaka Katu; traditionally considered to balance all three doshas, especially Kapha and Vata.

Guggul - History and traditional use: Guggul has been used in Ayurvedic and Unani medicine for about 3,000 years, and Ayurvedic texts mentioning it date to around 600 BC. The resin is also burned as incense (dhoop) and used in perfumes.

Guggul - Key constituents: Guggulsterone, a steroid that acts as an antagonist of the farnesoid X receptor (FXR). More than 100 metabolites have been reported, including high levels of quinic acid and myo-inositol in fruits and leaves.

Guggul - Modern evidence on cholesterol: Guggulsterone was once thought to reduce liver cholesterol synthesis, but several studies at various doses found no overall reduction in total cholesterol, and in many people LDL (bad) cholesterol increased.

Guggul - Conservation status (important): The IUCN Red List classifies *Commiphora wightii* as Critically Endangered. Overharvesting for traditional medicine has made it scarce in its two Indian habitats, Gujarat and Rajasthan. Responses include a National Medicinal Plants Board cultivation project in Kutch district and a grassroots movement promoting sustainable harvesting.

Guggul - Safety: The sources used for this sheet do not cover guggul side effects, interactions or pregnancy. Because it can raise LDL cholesterol in some people and is used with cholesterol and thyroid concerns, it should only be used with practitioner or doctor guidance.

Pippali (Long pepper)

Piper longum

AYU-015
Herb (fruit spike)

Pippali (Long pepper) - Names: Pippali in Sanskrit (from the Dravidian tippali), Indian long pepper in English.

Pippali (Long pepper) - Botanical identity: *Piper longum*, family Piperaceae, a flowering vine.

Pippali (Long pepper) - Parts used: The dried fruit is used as a spice and seasoning; the tiny fruits are embedded in a flower spike that looks like a hazel catkin. The root (Pippalimula) is also used in Ayurveda (commonly cited).

Pippali (Long pepper) - Ayurvedic properties (commonly cited classical summary; sources vary): Rasa Katu (pungent); guna Laghu, Snigdha and Teekshna; virya mildly Ushna; vipaka Madhura. It is considered to pacify Vata and Kapha and is a classical rasayana in small doses. Along with dried ginger and black pepper it forms the classical trio Trikatu.

Pippali (Long pepper) - Key constituents: Piperine, present in the fruits, gives the pungency. Piperlonguminine is another compound studied in the laboratory.

Pippali (Long pepper) - Modern research: One laboratory study reported that piperlonguminine inhibited melanin production in melanoma B16 cells by downregulating tyrosinase, and another reported barrier-protective effects in lipopolysaccharide-induced inflammation in cells and animals. No clinical evidence for long pepper is described in the sources.

Pippali (Long pepper) - History: Hippocrates discussed long pepper as a medicine rather than a spice.

Pippali (Long pepper) - Safety: The sources used for this sheet do not cover long pepper safety, interactions or pregnancy. Because it is very pungent and often used to enhance the effect of other herbs, it should be used under practitioner guidance, particularly in pregnancy, in ulcers or acidity and alongside regular medicines.

Quick comparison of the 15 entries

Each row reads: herb, part used, main classical action, key caution. Reference only; see each entry for detail and sources.

Herb	Part used	Main classical action	Key caution
Ashwagandha	Root	Rasayana, balya, vajikarana	Liver injury reports; avoid in pregnancy; hormone-sensitive conditions
Neem	Leaf, bark, seed oil	Kandughna (itching), skin disorders	Neem oil toxic to small children; pregnancy; low blood sugar
Turmeric	Rhizome	Krimighna, kushtaghna, varnya	Rare liver injury with concentrated supplements; lead adulteration
Tulsi	Leaf	Cough and respiratory complaints	Safety data not covered; consult practitioner
Amla	Fruit	Rasayana; part of Triphala	Safety data not covered; consult practitioner
Brahmi	Whole plant	Medhya (memory, mind)	Nausea, stomach upset; unproven claims
Guduchi	Stem	Rasayana, fever, jaundice, skin	Liver injury, autoimmune-like hepatitis; avoid in liver or autoimmune disease
Shatavari	Tuberous root	Stanyajanana, rasayana, women's health	Limited safety data; pregnancy needs advice
Triphala	Three fruits	Rasayana, digestive and metabolic	Product quality; pregnancy needs advice
Ginger	Rhizome	Digestive, Vata-Kapha balancing	Interacts with anticoagulants; gallstones; heartburn
Haritaki	Fruit	Tridoshahara, especially Vata	Safety data not covered; consult practitioner
Arjuna	Bark	Hridya (heart-supporting)	Heart patients only under doctor supervision
Licorice	Root	Throat, respiratory, ulcers	High blood pressure, low potassium; avoid in pregnancy
Guggul	Gum resin	Traditional metabolic and joint use	Critically Endangered; LDL may rise
Pippali	Fruit spike	Katu, Vata-Kapha balancing, rasayana	Very pungent; use under guidance

Glossary

Rasa: Taste of a substance: Madhura (sweet), Amla (sour), Lavana (salty), Katu (pungent), Tikta (bitter), Kashaya (astringent).

Guna: Qualities such as Laghu (light), Guru (heavy), Snigdha (unctuous), Ruksha (dry), Teekshna (sharp).

Virya: Potency, either Ushna (heating) or Sheeta (cooling).

Vipaka: Post-digestive effect, usually Madhura (sweet), Amla (sour) or Katu (pungent).

Prabhava: A special action that cannot be explained by rasa, guna, virya or vipaka.

Dosha: The three functional principles Vata, Pitta and Kapha. Shamaka or hara means pacifying or alleviating a dosha.

Rasayana: Rejuvenative therapy or herb, traditionally used for vitality and longevity.

Churna, kwatha, swarasa, taila: Powder, decoction, fresh juice and medicated oil, the common classical dose forms.

Nighantu: A classical Ayurvedic lexicon describing the properties of medicinal substances, for example Bhavaprakasha Nighantu and Dhanvantari Nighantu.

Herb-induced liver injury (HILI): Liver damage caused by a herbal product, ranging from mild enzyme rises to acute liver failure.

Sources and references

All web sources were read on 19 October 2026. Facts are summarised in our own words. Please verify against the original sources, and against the Ayurvedic Pharmacopoeia of India and primary classical texts, before any academic or clinical use.

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